

One reason the wife needs a will is because in a common accident the assets of the estate can pass to her. If she has no will, she dies intestate and the court handles the estate.

WHEN TO GIVE AN INHERITANCE?

I don't suggest giving children their inheritance when they're 6 years old or even 18. But at some point, begin to distribute the assets you want them to have. If you die prematurely, your will or trust should specify when distributions should be made to your children. I would suggest staggering payments over several years; for example, at ages 25, 30, 35, and so on. That way the children are older and hopefully wiser.

A common problem is a widow left to manage assets that have to last her for the rest of her life but who has little or no knowledge of what to do. I believe that every husband, at least once a year, needs to sit down and write his wife a letter, detailing what she should do in the event of his death. List all the assets, including insurance and investments, and give her counsel on what you would do if you were there and had the funds available. Wives need to be *sure* this is done.

I have counseled enough widows to know that too often they don't even know where the insurance policies are. They have no idea of whether it's better to take the insurance in cash or an annuity. These questions can be simplified greatly by investing the few minutes it takes once a year to discuss these key matters.

Obviously, a wife needs to understand how to manage the finances of the home. I have met women who said, "I just don't want to do it. My husband keeps the books and pays the bills." Every wife needs to manage the books in the home for some period of time, at least enough to know how.

Statistics tell us that the vast majority of the time, the husband predeceases his wife, and the average age at which a woman is widowed is 52. I told that at a conference not long ago, and a man responded, "If I divorce my wife when she's 51, I'm bound to live longer, right?" No, it doesn't work that way.